



ARE YOU DRYING YOUR BEST?

The benefits of using a dry-off facilitator

Dairy experts are encouraging farmers to reassess their approach to the dry-off process and to focus on the three axes of **Management**, **Udder Health** and **Welfare** at dry-off when considering their methods.



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At dry-off other aspects besides udder health such, as the management and welfare should be considered as they are inter-related. Drying off is a challenging time for the farmer and the cow, with a number of practices which need to be put in place to make sure cow outcomes are optimised. These challenges are in selecting appropriate therapies as well as ensure there are appropriate management schemes to minimise the risk to udder health and welfare during the dry period

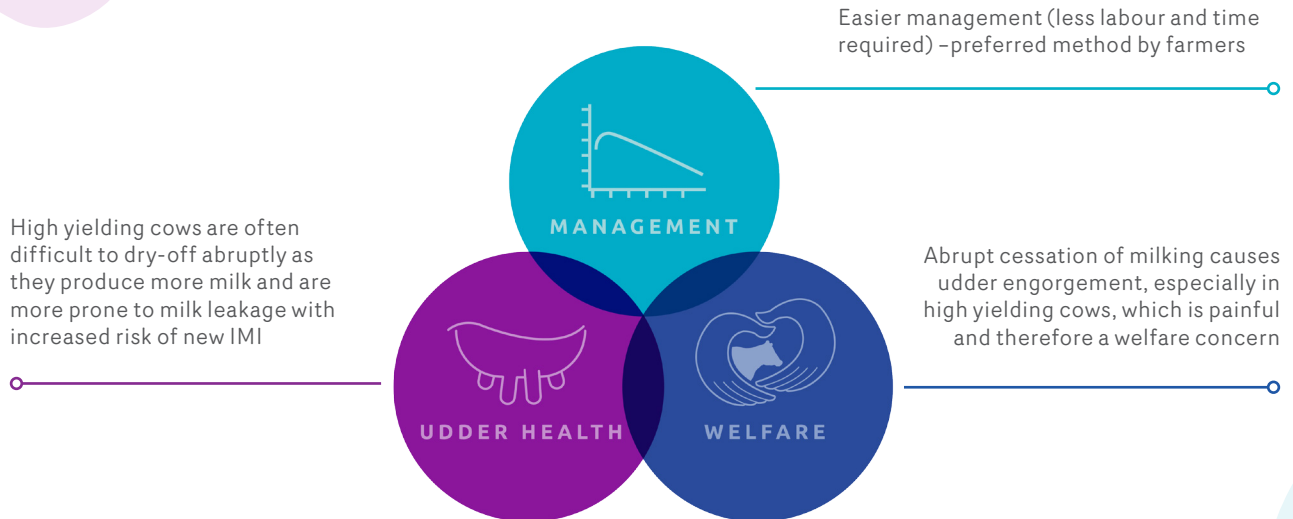
– Dr. Alex Bach, IRTA (Spain)

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Traditional methods include abrupt and gradual dry-off:

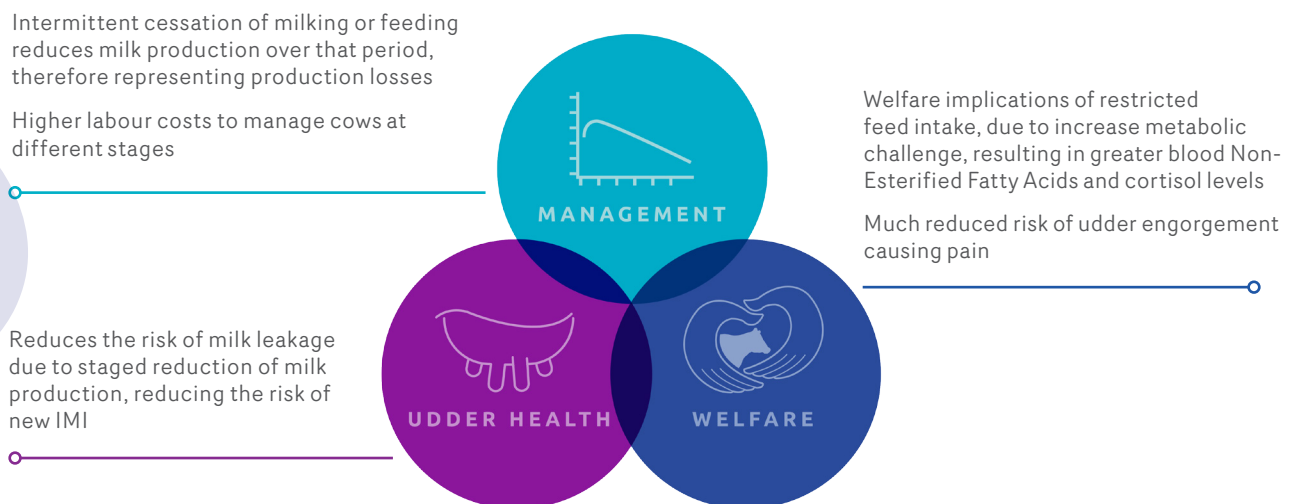
Abrupt dry-off

Milk production is stopped by a sudden cessation of milking:



Gradual dry-off

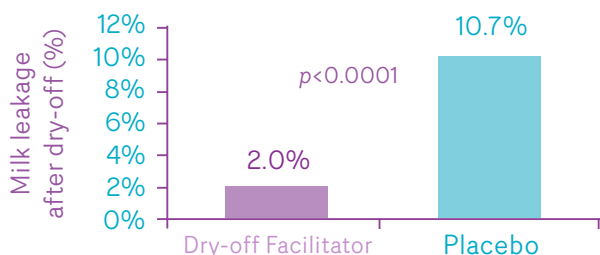
Milk production is gradually reduced by different means (reduced feeding and/or milking frequency) before the day of dry-off:



A dry-off facilitator can be utilised alongside the abrupt dry-off method to optimise **management**, **udder health** and **welfare** at dry-off. A single injection reduces milk production in the udder, by suppressing the release of the milk-producing hormone, prolactin, in the brain.

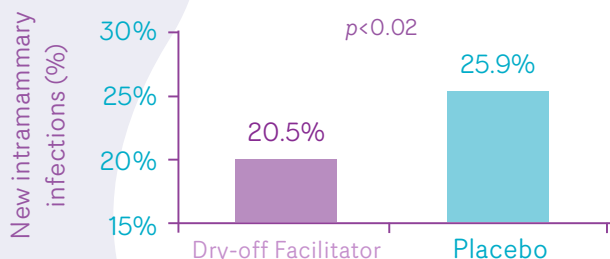
Multiple clinical trials have shown that using a dry off facilitator at dry-off to have a positive impact on the management, udder health and welfare of dairy cattle by:

1. Reducing milk leakage incidence at dry-off (81%)



Percentage of cows with milk leakage the Day 1 after DO considering treatment: Dry-off Facilitator and Placebo

2. Preventing the risk of new intramammary infections during the dry period (21%)



Percentage of new IMI after calving at quarter level

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Cows infected at drying off can have a case of clinical mastitis 200 days into milk that is linked to that infection. You need to know where the source of infection is coming from. The reality is that most cases of mastitis seen in the first month of lactation have their origins in the dry period.

– Dr. Andrew Bradley, QMMS (UK)

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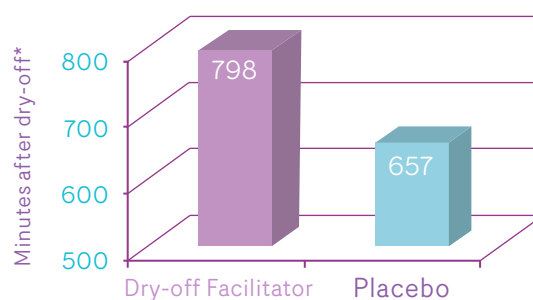
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Good husbandry practices, such as providing cows with a clean, comfortable environment, and avoiding competition as much as possible when regrouping, are critically important strategies to improve the welfare of cows during the dry period. Additionally, reducing udder engorgement after drying off is very useful to reduce pain and discomfort, as well as the risk of new intramammary infections.

– Dr. Xavier Manteca, UAB (Spain)

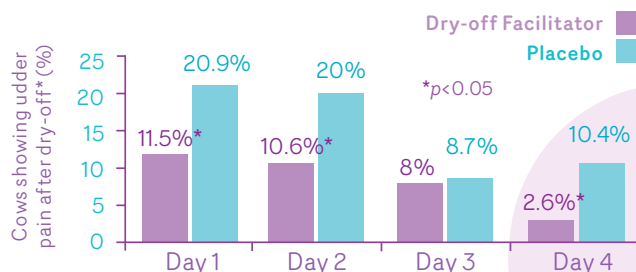
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3. Reducing pain and discomfort after dry-off (86%)



On day 1 after dry-off lying time was significantly higher in the Dry-off Facilitator group (798 minutes) than in the Placebo group (657 minutes) ($p < 0.0001^*$).

The cows in the Dry-off Facilitator group had 2 hours 35 minutes more lying time.



Percentage of cows presenting udder pain after dry-off